

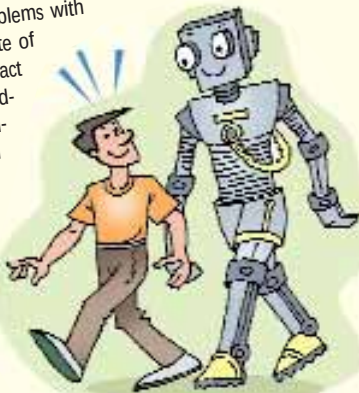
Divergent on convergence

Dear Vinit,
I read your column 'All for One and One for All' on convergence in the July 2001 issue. I expect that my washing machine and microwave are eventually going to shrink into a single device that will do the dishes after cooking the turkey. But do you think this is good? If everything becomes easier, eventually the entire world will have to be dependent on machines, which is something that I personally don't want to happen. I believe technology should continue in harmony with nature and humans instead of being in conflict with them.

Today, the US is facing problems with landfills due to the high rate of obsolescence of PCs. The fact that silicon is not bio-degradable doesn't make the situation any better. While I am striving to make a career for myself in computers I don't want them to take over my daily life.

JAYDEV DHAKAN

Via e-mail



Illustrations: Farzana Cooper

digit

Vinit Aggarwal responds:

Jay,

My column was focused on the convergence of entertainment and technology and not really about how smart machines will eventually make mankind redundant. I think movies such as *Terminator* and *The Matrix* have dealt with this in great detail. Your microwave already doubles up as an oven, your fax machine can be used as a copier, your washing machine also dries your clothes and universal remote controls can operate multiple appliances. Whether we like it or not, convergence is happening. While I personally prefer multifunctional devices, I guess that is a matter of personal choice.

digit

Dear Subhradyuti, Dhinesh, and many others,
As we expected, the story, 'The Promised Goal' has attracted a lot of feedback from all quarters. There are a lot of varied opinions on this. Some of you have written in saying that you agree with the fact that computer education provided by colleges in India are lacking in many ways. Others have vociferously defended the contents of the curriculum. As one reader that wrote in to us said, "Colleges help you get a strong foundation in the fundamentals, which will be useful for the rest of your lives." And there were those that felt that it doesn't really matter because "it's just another subject".

One thing that comes out clearly from this is that the levels of satisfaction vary according to the expectations that each of us has of our education system. Not everyone can afford a three-year computer course from a private institute in addition to college (or study in IIT for that matter). Many of us expect that our college courses should go beyond just providing a degree. It should be designed to prepare us for our careers. And everyone has his own view on whether three or four years of computer education in colleges is time well spent.

Teach me not

Dear Digit,

This is in response to the article 'The Promised Goal' carried in the July 2001 issue. I graduated from one of the 300 engineering colleges affiliated to the Madras University. I chose Computer Science but found that the lab, which was established way back in 1984, still used Windows 3.1. The languages we learnt were Pascal, C, C++, Fortran and Cobol. Through the eight semesters, which also included some civil, mechanical, electrical and lots of electronics subjects, most of my class of 74 students, including myself, chose to join some private computer institutes in Chennai. Here we learnt Java, Oracle, ASP and JavaScript over a two-year period. When we got out of college we had knowledge of only the basics without a clue of what skills are needed in the real world. I am so confused and disheartened that I just want to get out of computers and join some other field. I now think that most engineering colleges are just a money making scam.

K. DHINESH

Via e-mail

Hi,

I read your article 'The Promised Goal' published in the July 2001 issue. I am a B.A. (Hons.) student of Business Economics in the second year of a Delhi University college. The course contents are quite professional except for two papers that deal with computers. I was taken aback to see that the contents of the course included BASIC, dBase Lotus and Wordstar. I have no idea why the university doesn't include programming languages like C++, VB or Java that have practical applications nowadays.

Initially, an ancient 486 had to be shared between three students and even though we later got newer PCs I realised that we didn't really learn much. In retrospect however, I understand that the outdated course makes it very easy to score higher marks. Since this means a higher overall percentage, I think this is an acceptable trade-off. You just need to make the best of the situation.

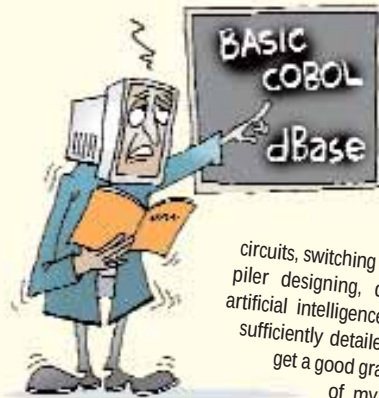
BHARAT CHHABRIA

Via e-mail

Sir,

I read your article 'The Promised Goal' in the July 2001 issue about the state of computer education in Government colleges and universities. The article was well written, but as a student of Computer Science in IIT Kharagpur, I would like to make a couple of observations of my own.

In IIT, our Computer Science Course is by no means outdated. We don't waste time learning archaic languages like Basic, Fortran and Cobol. We started with C, and then graduated to C++ and Java. The professors meet frequently to revise the syllabi to make it up-to-date.



We may not learn the use of actual tools like VC++ or VB in the classroom, but our professors encourage us to pursue personal projects. What we do learn are fundamentals such as digital

circuits, switching theory, algorithms, compiler designing, database management, artificial intelligence, etc. The courses are sufficiently detailed and coherent, so we get a good grasp of everything. Some of my friends who study in

renowned private institutions are good at using various tools and compilers, but they lack this basic knowledge. So I think it unfair to include the IITs when you claim that what people learn in engineering colleges around the country is by and large rubbish.

SUBHRADYUTI SARKAR, IIT KHARAGPUR

Via e-mail